MARCELO GANTIER-MITA

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Development Economics, Political Economy, Environmental Economics.

EDUCATION

PhD in Economics *2022-2027 (expected)*
Paris School of Economics
Advisor: Professor Karen Macours
Thesis committee member: Professor Oliver Vanden Eynde

Visiting PhD Student *Sept. 2025-April 2026*
Vancouver School of Economics, University of British Columbia
Host: Professor Claudio Ferraz

Master in Public Policy and Development, with *summa cum laude* *2022*
Paris School of Economics
Advisor: Professor Karen Macours

MSc. in Economics, with *Distinction* *2019*
The University of Warwick
Advisor: Professor James Fenske

B.A. in Economics *2011-2015*
Bolivian Catholic University (UCB)

WORKING PAPERS

- **"Bringing Services Closer to People? Distance to Administrators and the Reach of the State"** *(Job Market Paper, latest draft November 2026)* [Policy Brief] [Blog Post]

Abstract: As populations grow, extending the reach of the state to a larger and more dispersed population becomes increasingly challenging. Many developing countries have responded by creating new subnational administrative units, bringing local administrators physically closer to citizens. Leveraging an episode of district proliferation in Uganda, this paper studies whether geographical proximity to local government administrative centers improves access to public goods and services and changes citizens' engagement with government. To establish causality, I exploit a policy implementation rule that generated exogenous variation in households' proximity to new district headquarters. Households living closer to these centers have significantly better access to electricity, roads, health facilities, and water sources. Proximity also shifts engagement from contentious to participatory channels and reduces direct experiences of corruption. Despite these gains, proximity does not increase trust in government or improve democratic perceptions, including in politically aligned districts where engagement effects are stronger. Finally, each district split raises transfers to the pre-split district territory by roughly 14 percent, with most of the increase concentrated in administrative expenditures rather than service delivery budgets.

- "Bottom-up Conservation: Sub-national Protected Areas and Local Governance in Bolivia" (with Julia Girard, Carlos Quezada-Lambertin and Jean Paul Benavides) *(draft available upon request)*

Abstract: Protected areas are central to global conservation policy, yet evidence on decentralized forest conservation remains limited. In many countries, local governments can designate protected areas while national governments retain authority over land allocation. This paper studies what happens when the authority to protect land is decentralized but the authority to allocate it is not. Combining annual land cover data, parcel-level titling records, and nearly 99,000 judicial rulings, we study Municipal Protected Areas in Bolivia using staggered difference in differences. We find that designation modestly reduces deforestation but does not prevent national land titling. In protected areas without indigenous territories, titling of commercial and medium-sized properties triples after designation, while small property titling remains unchanged. Titled land is subsequently cleared at similar rates inside and outside protected areas. Titling is initiated by private claimants and faces little apparent legal contestation, with no judicial ruling challenging titles granted inside municipal protected areas. Where protection overlaps indigenous territories, titling does not increase, and the national land agency defends indigenous tenure in court. These findings suggest that indigenous territorial rights provide an institutional constraint on national land allocation that is absent under municipal protection alone.

- "Voting for Justice? Judicial Elections and Checks and Balances in Bolivia"

  Abstract: In 2011, Bolivia became the first country to select its highest court judges by popular vote, aiming to democratize justice and strengthen judicial legitimacy. This paper studies whether the reform affected the courts' capacity to check the executive. Using the universe of high-court rulings since 2000, I compare outcomes in politically sensitive cases before and after the reform in a difference in differences setting. Preliminary findings suggest that, after the reform, the constitutional court became more likely to rule in favor of the government in cases where political power is directly at stake, including removal from office and electoral disputes. In the criminal chamber of the supreme court, appeals filed by accused public officials became more likely to be admitted and to succeed. These patterns are not present before the reform and become stronger under the second cohort of elected judges. Taken together, the evidence suggests that the popular election of judges, combined with government control over candidate pre-selection, may have facilitated political capture rather than strengthened checks and balances.

WORK IN PROGRESS

- "Turkish Soap Operas and Intimate Partner Violence in Peru"
- "Livestock Intensification, Structural Transformation, and Environmental Spillovers" (with Matthew Gordon, Karen Macours and Antonia Marcheva)
- "Building Skills in Agri-Food Systems: A Meta-Analysis of Extension and Training Programs" (with Karen Macours, Balasai Vanukuri and Amit Khanal)
- "Impact of Land Tenure on Tropical Working Lands" (with Daniela Miteva, Subhrendu Pattanayak, Erin Sills, Alex Pfaff, Allen Blackman, et al.)
- "An Unlikely Shield: Informal Settlements and Political Violence in Peru" (with Hector Paredes)

POLICY REPORTS

- "Measuring Livestock: A Review of Data Gaps and Methodological Opportunities for Livestock Data Collection in Household and Agricultural Surveys", August 2025.

PRE-DOCTORAL PUBLICATIONS

Papers in Refereed Journals

- "Subjective Expectations and Schooling Choices in Latin America and the Caribbean" (with Andrea Repetto and Rafael Novella) *Journal of International Development*, 36(3), 1593-1621, 2024.
- "The effect of Government Expenditure on the Economy of Bolivia: an analysis of the 1990-2015 period" (with Germán Molina), *Revista Perspectivas No. 39*, May 2017 *(In Spanish).*

Working Papers

- "Commodity Shocks, Factor Intensity and Conflicts in Africa", *IISEC Working Papers series 6/20*, November 2020 *(based on my MSc dissertation, University of Warwick).*
- "The Challenge of Tracking the Reach of Post-Green Revolution Crop Breeding" (with James Stevenson, Greg Traxler, Frederic Kosmowski, and Karen Macours), June 2023.

Book Chapters

- "Rent-seeking in a High Natural Resources Dependency Environment: The case of Bolivia" (with Bernardo Fernández y Martín Palmero) in Research for Bolivian Economic Development, *Academia Boliviana de Ciencias Economicas - Fundación INESAD*, Pag. 169-228, 2019 *(In Spanish).* [Working paper version] [Media coverage]
- "The relationship between natural resources and local human development: A blessing or a curse?" in Growth Inequality and the Challenge for sustainability (with Horacio Vera), *Konrad Adenauer Stiftung*, Pag. 141-156, 2018.

- Towards sustainable development in the Andean Region (with Fernanda Wanderley, Horacio Vera, Jean Paul Benavides and Karen Martinez), *Institute of Socio Economic Research (IISEC-UCB)*, 2018 *(In Spanish).*

Policy Reports

- "Social Debt in Bolivia" (Fernanda Wanderley and Jaime Perez coordinators), *Institute of Socio Economic Research*, July 2017 *(In Spanish).*

EXTERNAL PRESENTATIONS

2027: ASSA Annual Meeting 2027 (AEA poster session)*

2026: STEG Annual Conference (Nairobi), PacDev 2026 (UC, Davis), Dev/PE internal seminar VSE-UBC, AFÉPOP 2026 (Strasbourg University), Nordic Conference on Development Economics (Linnaeus University), International Conference in Development Economics (AFEDEV - Rouen University), 2nd Junior Workshop on Economics of Latin America (Berlin School of Economics), Oxford Development Economics Workshop (OxDev) 2026, Bruneck Workshop on Political Economy*

2025: Applied Research Workshop (Bolivian Catholic University)

2024: EPD Jamboree (Pompeu Fabra University), 2nd Essex PhD Conference in Applied Economics 12th Warwick Economics PhD Conference, Monthly Seminar Series Makerere Unversity, Bolivian Conference on Development Economics (15th BCDE)

2023: International Conference in Development Economics (AFEDEV - Paris School of Economics), Bolivian Conference on Development Economics (14th BCDE)

*Scheduled

RESEARCH GRANTS

2025:	Paris School of Economics, Mobility Grant	EUR 6,000
	Université Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne, Mobility Grant	EUR 3,000
	CNRS-PSE Development Group, *Voting for Justice?*	EUR 1,000
2024:	CNRS-PSE Development Group, *Bottom-up Conservation*	EUR 1,500
	Agence Nationale de la Recherche EUR-PgSE, *Turkish Soap Operas*	EUR 2,500
	CNRS-PSE Development Group, *Livestock Measurement*	EUR 1,000
	International Growth Centre (IGC), *Job Market Paper*	GBP 4,135
	Agence Nationale de la Recherche EUR-PgSE, *Job Market Paper*	EUR 4,000
2018:	CAF / A.B.C.E. / INESAD, *Rent-seeking in Bolivia*	USD 12,500

AWARDS AND DISTINCTIONS

Doctoral Contract ED 465 (Paris 1 Pantheon-Sorbonne) *2022*
Recipient of a Full Scholarship to study at The Paris School of Economics

Master PPD Scholarship (Paris School of Economics) *2021*
Recipient of a Partial Scholarship to study at The Paris School of Economics

Chevening Scholarship (Foreign and Commonwealth Office - UK) *2018*
Recipient of a Full Scholarship to study at The University of Warwick

IISEC-UCB Scholarship for the Summer School "Multidimensional Poverty" *2017*
Oxford Poverty and Human Development Initiative (OPHI), University of Oxford

National Award for the Best Undergraduate Dissertation in Economics *2016*
Central Bank of Bolivia, 9th Bolivian Economists' Forum

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, Econometrics II: Treatment Effect Models *2023-24, 2024-25*
Master in Public Policy and Development, Paris School of Economics
Best Teaching Assistant Award, Master PPD, academic year 2023/2024

Lecturer, Macroeconomics II *2020*
Bolivian Catholic University

Lecturer, General Economics (Econ 101) *2017-2018*
Bolivian Catholic University

Teaching Assistant, Econometrics I & II (2014-2015), Macroeconomics I (2013-2014), General Economics (2012)
Bolivian Catholic University

Short courses: Multidimensional Poverty Measurement (Bolivian Catholic University, 2017); Introduction to Stata Programming (Universidad Mayor de San Andrés, 2016); Household Surveys and Applications in Stata (Bolivian Catholic University, 2016).

PREVIOUS APPOINTMENTS

Short Term Consultant *World Bank (TTL Sydney Gourlay)* *Mar 2025 - June 2025*
Research Assistant *for Prof. Karen Macours (PSE)* *July 2022 - Aug 2022*
Pre-doctoral Fellow *Research Assistant for Prof. Karen Macours (PSE)/ SPIA-CGIAR* *Sep 2020 - Sep 2021*
Consultant *Inter-American Development Bank (IADB)* *Oct 2019 - May 2020*
Junior Researcher *Institute of Socio Economic Research (IISEC-UCB)* *Aug 2016 - Jun 2018*
Assistant Editor LAJED Journal *Institute of Socio Economic Research (IISEC-UCB)* *Aug 2016 - Jun 2018*
Research Assistant *Institute of Socio Economic Research (IISEC-UCB)* *Feb 2014 - Jul 2016*

AFFILIATIONS

American Economic Association (AEA), European Economic Association (EEA), Latin American and Caribbean Economic Association (LACEA), Association Française d'Économie du Développement (AFEDEV), Association Française des Économistes de la Population (AFÉPOP), Elected member of the directors' board at the Bolivian Society of Economists (SEBOL) 2024-2026.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Referee: Journal of Development Economics, Latin American Journal of Economic Development (LAJED), EAYE Annual Meeting 2026, Bolivian Conference on Development Economics 2026.
Seminar and conference organization: Development Economics Seminar, Paris School of Economics, 2024-2025; Bolivian Conference on Development Economics (BCDE), 2024 and 2025.
Mentoring: EconThaki, 2024.

OTHER INFORMATION

Programming: Stata, R, Python, LaTeX, ArcGIS/QGIS.
Languages: Spanish (native), English (advanced), French (intermediate).

REFERENCES

Karen Macours
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Oliver Vanden Eynde
Paris School of Economics
Thesis Committee Member
✉ o.vandeneynde@psemail.eu

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Last updated: October 2026